

A JPP RESOURCE COLLECTION GUIDE

BATTLES BEYOND THE WAVES

Reader & Discussion Guide

BARBARA J. RATLIFF

For Book Clubs · Veterans & Military Communities · Faith Communities
Community Groups · Individual Readers

The book may end. The conversation doesn't have to.



About This Book

Battles Beyond the Waves · Barbara J. Ratliff

Battles Beyond the Waves is the memoir of Barbara J. Ratliff, a United States military veteran, author, and publisher. It is a book about service and the battles that continue long after homecoming. With honesty and courage, Barbara shares her experiences of military service, military sexual trauma, grief, loss, transition, and the long road toward healing, faith, and purpose.

This is not a book about a person who had everything figured out. It is a book about a person who kept going anyway: one step, one day, one act of faith at a time. It is a story for anyone who has ever survived something hard and wondered what comes next.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

To every reader who picks up this book,

*I did not write *Battles Beyond the Waves* to be celebrated. I wrote it to be honest. There were years when I carried things in silence because I did not believe my story was worth telling, or that anyone would want to hear it.*

What I know now is this: silence protects pain. Truth creates freedom.

Not just for the person speaking, but for every person who hears it and realizes they are not alone.

If this book opens a door for you, to a conversation you have been avoiding, a feeling you have been carrying, or a part of your own story you have not yet spoken aloud, then it has done exactly what I hoped it would do.

You do not have to carry it alone.

— Barbara J. Ratliff

Before the Conversation Begins

This guide is designed to open conversation, not close it. There are no right or wrong answers, and no participant should feel required to disclose a personal experience.

Participation is an invitation, not an obligation. Anyone may pass on a question. Different interpretations should be respected, and personal stories shared within the group should be treated with care.

FOR THE HOST

You do not need to ask every question. Choose the prompts that best fit your group and the time available. Allow the conversation to develop naturally, and make room for silence when a question needs time to settle.

READ WITH CARE

The book includes discussion of military sexual trauma, grief, loss, transition, and difficult life experiences. Let participants know the subject matter in advance so they can decide how they wish to engage.

A SIMPLE GROUP AGREEMENT

PASS

Anyone may pass on any question.

LISTEN

Make room for perspectives different from your own.

PRIVACY

Treat personal stories shared in the room with care.

PAUSE

Silence is allowed. Not every moment needs to be filled.

Three Central Themes

I

SURVIVAL BEYOND TRAUMA

Survival Is Not the End of the Story

Trauma does not have to be the final chapter. This book follows the long journey from surviving to truly living, toward healing, purpose, and peace.

II

BREAKING SILENCE THROUGH TRUTH

Silence Protects Pain. Truth Creates Freedom.

For years, many veterans, women, and survivors carry burdens they never speak about. This story demonstrates the cost of silence and the power of finally telling the truth.

III

FAITH, LOVE & HUMAN CONNECTION

Faith, Love, and Human Connection Carry Us Through

Strength does not mean standing alone. Throughout this memoir there are anchors: a grandmother's influence, a husband's support, family, faith, and people who showed up. Even in the darkest season, there is hope.

Discussion Questions

PART ONE Surviving

Survival Is Not the End of the Story

- 1 Barbara's story does not end with surviving; it continues through the long, difficult work of learning how to live afterward. What part of her journey toward healing resonated most with you, and why?
- 2 The book shows that healing is rarely linear. There are setbacks, silences, and seasons of going backward before moving forward. How did Barbara's experience of non-linear healing connect with what you know about recovery, your own or someone you love?
- 3 Barbara transitions from military life to civilian life, which carries its own kind of grief and disorientation. What did her description of that transition teach you about the challenges veterans face that often go unacknowledged?
- 4 By the end of the book, Barbara has built a life of purpose as an author, publisher, and advocate. How do you think her painful experiences shaped the mission she now carries? Can suffering become a foundation rather than just a wound?

PART TWO Speaking

Silence Protects Pain. Truth Creates Freedom.

- 5 Military sexual trauma is one of the most underreported and misunderstood experiences in the veteran community. Before reading this book, what did you know, or not know, about MST? How has your understanding changed?
- 6 Barbara carried certain truths in silence for years before writing them down. What do you think silence costs a person over time, emotionally, physically, spiritually? Have you ever held something in silence longer than it served you?
- 7 The act of writing this memoir was itself an act of truth-telling. Do you believe storytelling can be a form of healing? Have you ever experienced the relief of finally saying something out loud, or reading something that said what you could not?
- 8 Who in your life, or in this book, modeled what it looks like to speak truth when it would have been easier to stay silent? What gave them the courage to do so?

Discussion Questions

PART THREE Connecting

Faith, Love, and Human Connection

- 9 Barbara's grandmother appears as a significant anchor in her life, a source of values, strength, and identity. Who in your life has served as that kind of anchor? What did they give you that you still carry?
- 10 Charles, Barbara's husband, represents steadfast love during some of her hardest seasons. What does his presence in the story say about what it means to truly support someone through trauma? What did his example teach you about love in practice?
- 11 Faith plays a meaningful role throughout the memoir. For those in your group who share a faith background, how did Barbara's relationship with faith during her darkest moments connect with your own experience? For those who do not, what served as your equivalent source of strength or grounding?
- 12 The title *Battles Beyond the Waves* suggests that the most significant battles are the ones fought on the inside, after the visible conflict is over. What battles, your own or those of someone you love, came to mind as you read?

PART FOUR Carrying It Forward

Closing Reflection

- 13 If you could say one thing directly to Barbara after reading this book, what would it be?
- 14 What is one thing this book gave you (a question, a realization, a memory, a renewed commitment) that you will carry with you after today's discussion?
- 15 Barbara wrote this book in part so that readers would know they are not alone. Did the book accomplish that for you? Is there someone in your life you feel called to share it with?
- 16 After reading the book, what does the phrase "*The Battles Shape You*" mean to you?

Your Own Shoreline

Not every battle leaves a visible scar, and not every victory arrives with applause.

These prompts are for you. You may share them with the group, keep them private, return to them later, or simply sit with the questions.

A season that shaped me was...

Something I understand differently today is...

Something I have learned to release is...

Something I am still sailing toward is...

You don't have to share what you write. Some reflections are meant first for you.

Facilitator Guidance

Book Clubs & Community Groups

BEFORE YOUR MEETING

Encourage members to read at their own pace and note the moments that stayed with them: a sentence, a scene, or a feeling.

Let your group know in advance that the book addresses military sexual trauma, grief, loss, transition, and difficult life experiences. Giving members context before the discussion helps them engage with care.

Consider opening with a few minutes of quiet reflection. This book benefits from a thoughtful arrival.

DURING YOUR DISCUSSION

You do not need to cover every question. Choose the ones that feel most alive for your group and follow them deeply rather than covering everything quickly.

Make space for silence. Some of the most powerful moments in a discussion happen just after a question lands.

Invite but never pressure personal sharing. If a question brings up strong emotion, acknowledge the person with care rather than trying to solve or interpret the experience.

Faith-Based Groups

Groups may choose to open with prayer or a reading that speaks to courage, truth, hope, or the journey toward wholeness. The faith questions also welcome participants who draw strength from nonreligious sources.

Veterans & Military Communities

Allow extra time for questions about transition, MST, silence, and invisible wounds. Veterans in the group may have their own experiences; let them decide what they wish to share and how deeply they wish to engage.

Continue the Conversation

The book may end. The conversation doesn't have to.

COFFEE & CONVERSATION WITH BARBARA

Barbara J. Ratliff is available for select book clubs, veteran groups, community organizations, faith communities, and Coffee & Conversation gatherings centered on *Battles Beyond the Waves*.

These conversations can include author Q&A, discussion of the book's themes, reflections on military transition and resilience, and the stories behind the story.

In-person

Virtual

Community Conversation

Book Club

Coffee & Conversation

SPEAKING & EVENT INQUIRIES

publisher@jackrabbitpunkinpublishing.com

JackrabbitPunkinPublishing.com

READ IT FORWARD

JPP's Read It Forward Program helps extend the reach of books into communities through sponsorship and support. Current sponsorship information and participation options are available through Jackrabbit Punkin Publishing.

JPP RESOURCE CENTER

Find more complimentary guides, activities, and educational materials in the JPP Resource Center.

[[Resource Center link](#)]

REACHING SHORE

*“You do not have to
carry it alone.”*

BARBARA J. RATLIFF

Stories That Inspire. Books That Endure.

Keep Learning

Find more complimentary guides, activities, and educational materials in the JPP Resource Center.

[[Resource Center link](#)]



This guide is intended to support reading and discussion. It is not a substitute for professional counseling, medical care, or crisis support.

Veterans and those who support them can reach the Veterans Crisis Line by dialing 988 and pressing 1.

Part of the Jackrabbit Punkin Publishing Resource Collection.

© 2026 JACKRABBIT PUNKIN PUBLISHING LLC